



Walrus

Odobenus rosmarus

This large marine mammal has a wide snout covered in hundreds of stiff, whiskerlike bristles called vibrissae, which help it to locate its food. Mollusks, such as mussels, are favorite foods, but walrus will eat the carcasses of young seals, usually when other food items are scarce.

The song of the walrus

Walrus travel in groups and “haul out” on land or ice. Females generally follow pack ice south in fall and north in spring, but most males stay all year in herds in the southern Arctic, only joining the females to mate. Bulls compete for mating locations by performing visual displays and intricate “songs,” and also spar with their tusks. A successful bull will mate with several cows between December and March, and the females give birth to a single calf in spring the following year.

The average lifespan of walrus in the wild is 40 years. They can withstand icy conditions because of their thick skin and the presence of vast amounts of blubbery fat around their shoulders and neck.

A walrus can slow its heartbeat to survive in icy water

△ TOOTH PICKS

Walrus use their tusks in defense and also as handy “ice picks” that help them pull themselves onto ice floes or land. They punch breathing holes through ice with their tusks, which grow about $\frac{1}{2}$ in (1cm) a year throughout their lives.

▷ COLD COMFORT

Normally cinnamon-brown, walrus may turn pale after a long stay in icy water as blood vessels in their skin constrict to save body heat. In warmer weather, some walrus look pink as their vessels dilate to get rid of excess heat.



- ↔ 8–12 ft (2.4–3.7 m)
- ⚖ Up to 2.2 tons (2 metric tons)
- ⊗ Not known
- 🐟 Mollusks, octopuses, fish
- 🏠 Arctic Ocean and coasts



Arctic Ocean and coasts